

CONTAGIOUS CHRISTIANITY

TEXT: Acts 1:8 (KJV) *“But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.”*

(USE ATTENDANCE BOARD TO HIGHLIGHT THE FOLLOWING)

- Saved Last week - 5
- Invited last week - 0
- Saved this week - 9
- Invited this week - 53

INTRO: When the word contagious is brought up the first thing all of us think about is some kind of disease which can be transmitted through contact. When we tack the word Christian on to the end of contagious we should be communicating the following message:

- A person whose life has been changed by a personal relationship with Jesus Christ
- A person who is so turned on to Christ that their personality resonates with enthusiasm for this new way of life
- A person who is using their influence to lead others toward Christ

If you are in the presence of a contagious Christian for any length of time, you will want to become one.

Everywhere Jesus went His presence brought about several reactions:

- A crowd gathered
- Friendships were developed
- The physical needs of people were ministered to
- The spiritual needs of the people were addressed
- Disciples were made

By definition being a Christian is to be “*Christ-like*.” If Jesus had such an impact on those He came into contact with should it not go without saying that authentic Christians should have the same effect?

Most Christians know they should be witnesses but fail to do so for a variety of reasons:

- Never find the time to do so
- Feel unqualified to do so
- Fear being rejected by the prospect
- Fear confronting people about their eternal destiny
- Fear they may not know how to close the deal if the person responds in a positive manner

No matter what our excuse may be, we still have a mandate placed upon us by the author of our salvation to share widely what we have freely received. If we are to give an account in eternity for how we bequeathed our faith I think most of us will be embarrassed with the accounting for such a thing.

Being witnesses is often not at the top of the list of priorities for most Christians. As a result, one of the

greatest short-coming in the church today is a failure of sharing our faith.

Today's church is long on programs, entertainment, fellowship, and talk; but too often short on results. Rather than making disciples, the church is creating obese Christians! **A disciple has not been made until we have created a disciple-making disciple.** (Illustrate this by bringing up a person whom I have reached and trained; have that person to bring up someone they have reached and trained; the person I have reached and trained is NOT a true DISCIPLE until they have reached and trained someone else.)

Oftentimes what we create is a “*groupie mentality.*” After a period of time, the same thing happened in the first century Church. ***“I am of Paul; I am of Apollos.”*** (Master's Commission)

The truth is that God called us to be His disciples so He could make us fishers of men. I wonder when fishing for men quit being our primary business. I was never taught to win souls, I was taught to stay away from the world.

(ILLUSTRATION)

I want to tell you a story about a group of people who fancied themselves to be fishermen. They lived in an area that was populated with lakes, rivers, streams, and ponds. The lakes, rivers, streams, and ponds were filled with all kinds of fresh water fish, and the fish were hungry, and would bite almost any kind of bait.

Week after week, month after month, year after year, these people who called themselves fishermen held meetings and talked about their call to be fishermen. They also talked about the abundance of fish and the latest innovations and technology in fishing trends. They were careful to articulate what fishing was all about, to defend fishing as a noble occupation, and passionately declared that fishing is always the primary task of fishermen.

They were constantly scouring the landscape searching for new and better methods of fishing. They loved such slogans as “Fishing is the primary task of every fisherman”. They sponsored special meetings known as “Fishermen’s campaigns”. They went on nation-wide and world-wide tours to discuss and promote fishing, and to hear all the new developments and technological developments in fishing. They even had exhaustive sessions on how to present the bait to the fish, and new way’s to make the bait more attractive and alluring to the fish!

They built large beautiful buildings called “Fishing Headquarters” and selected some of their best fishermen to staff it. They appealed to everyone to become fishermen. There was only one thing they did not do, fish, ever!!!

In addition to organizing and holding regularly scheduled meetings, they organized a board to oversee the “Fishing Headquarters” and to send fishermen out to other parts of the world where the fish were equally plentiful and available. The board appointed various

committees and held numerous fishing meetings to talk about fishing, to defend fishing, and develop new strategies for fishing. But the overseers of the “Fishing Headquarters”, the staff, the board, or the committees never went fishing!

Large expensive training centers known as “Fishing Schools” were built for the purpose of teaching fishermen how to fish. They offered courses on the needs of fish, the nature of fish, the ancestral backgrounds of fish, the psychological makeup of fish, and how to approach and feed fish. The professors all had degrees in fishology, but none of them ever went fishing! After completing the course of study, the graduates were given a fishing license and were sent out to fish full time. Some decided to fish locally, others moved away from their local surroundings, and still others went to distant lands to fish. They, in turn, trained and commissioned others to fish. Like the fishermen back home, they often talked for hours on the need to fish, the current trends in fishing, and how to fish. Even though it was really their heart’s desire to fish, these new fishermen became too busy to actually fish. Because they were too busy to fish they recruited others to fish (called them recruits or disciples), furnished fishing equipment they also taught their fishing disciples to develop good relationships with the fish so the fish would be more receptive to other fishermen.

After one stirring meeting on “The Necessity of Fishing,” one young fellow left the meeting and actually went fishing! At the next fishermen’s meeting

he reported an outstanding catch! He was honored for his excellent catch, and immediately a nation-wide tour was scheduled so he could motivate others to go fishing! In order to have time for these motivational meetings, he was forced to dispense with full-time fishing and become a recreational fisherman. He became so successful on the motivational circuit that he was called upon to serve on the "Fishermen's General Board," which consumed so much time that he had no time for fishing at all!

Now it is true that many of the fishermen made personal sacrifices and tolerated all kinds of difficulties. Some lived near the water and had to bear the smell of dead and decaying fish all the time. They were even ridiculed by some who were constantly making fun of their fishermen clubs. What they did not realize was the reason they were being ridiculed was because they were always talking about fishing - but never fishing! People outside fishing circles actually wondered if all this talk and no action might possibly be a waste of the fisherman's time.

Imagine how deeply they were hurt when someone suggested that those who don't fish are not actually fishermen!

I am placing Christian Temple on notice today that **our focus this year will be five-fold:**

- **Simplify the church** (Less programs, more time for fishing)
- **Build a discipleship track to run on for all who desire to become a properly trained Christian**

- Encourage each adherent to get acquainted with some fish (It is about relationships, relationships, relationships...)
- Challenge each person to go fishing (If not winning souls, at least invite the person to come to church with you)
- Provide ongoing ideas and accountability for every person who is willing to enlist in an effort to fish (Give all kinds of relational ideas for building bridges to the lost in an attempt to reach them)

Some questions we should be asking ourselves:

- Are we really interested in fishing?
- Is fishing a priority in each of our lives?
- Would we rather fish or watch others fish?
- If we are so interested in fishing, where are the fish?

We are coming down to the end of this dispensation and it is no longer acceptable to:

- Enjoy the idea of fishing
- Become excited when others fish
- Celebrate when others actually catch fish

Christianity Today published the following statistics:

- 160 Million People in the U.S. are un-churched (Un-churched being defined as going to church two times or less in one year)
- 96% or 153 million people would go to church if they were invited

- Only 21% of church-goers invite anyone to church in the course of a year
- Only 2% of church-goers invite an un-churched person to attend church with them in the course of a year

What does an un-churched person consider to be an invitation?

- For some, it was just a simple, *“I would like to invite you to attend my church”*
- For some, it is an invitation by the believer to meet the un-churched at the church to sit with them during the service
- For some, it was an invitation on the part of the believer to show the un-churched person around the church facilities
- For some, it was an invitation extended by the believer to the un-churched to sit with them during the service then meet them for a meal at a local restaurant following the service

It is time for all Christians to drop a line in the water and go fishing!

SURVEY THE CONGREGATION:

Your age: 12-18 19-25 26-35 36-45 46-65 66-85 85+

- How long have you been a Christian? _____
- How many people have you personally led to Christ? ____
- How many people did you invite to church with you during 2007? _____

- Is there any reason you would not invite a friend or family member to attend CT with you? (If yes, explain) _____

- Are you equipped with the tools that you need to lead your friends and family to Christ and to disciple them? If not, what do you lack? _____

END OF SERMON ONE

(USE ATTENDANCE BOARD TO HIGHLIGHT THE FOLLOWING)

- Saved Last week - 9
- Invited last week -53
- Saved this week - 13
- Invited this week - 64

(GO BACK OVER THE ILLUSTRATION OF CREATING A DISCIPLE MAKING DISCIPLE)

I think most of the responsibility for a woeful lack of contagious Christianity must be laid at the doorstep of Pastors. A large part of [the work of a Pastor is to equip the Saints for works of ministry.](#) Ephesians 4:11-12 (NKJV) ***“And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, ¹²for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ.”*** (BRING THE STAFF UP AND TALK ABOUT THE EXPECTATIONS OF THE CHURCH WITH REGARD TO THEM – WE HIRED THEM

TO BUILD THE CHURCH) According to this Scripture the Pastor has the following God given responsibilities:

- Provide discipleship training for new Christians
- Consistently encourage all Christians
- Make available ongoing training for mature Christians
- Constantly develop vocational ministers and lay leaders
- Teach all Christians to walk in the Spirit
- Teach all Christians to allow the gifts of the Spirit to flow through them
- Equip lay people to do the ministry
- Motivate lay people to become soul-winners
- Provide lay people with ideas for soul-winning

Based on the statistics I shared last week, it appears that most Christians don't believe they have a responsibility to share their faith with others.

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Most Christians who decide to share their faith do so in subtle ways, such as offering to pray for someone who is in need or leaving a tract on the table at the restaurant. There is nothing wrong with either one of these ideas, but we must become much more aggressive when it comes to being a contagious Christian.

There is no doubt that some congregations are stagnant. Church members have gotten comfortable in their air-conditioned, carpeted, stained-glass sanctuaries. Church growth has been crippled because we have lost our evangelistic fervor to the point that some of us no longer have any friendships with people who do not know Christ!

National studies over the past couple of decades show that church attendance is in decline and the churches that are growing are doing so through transfer growth. The church must return to the frame of mind that views the great commission as more than a nice little idea.

The philosophical stance of the church must be that the great commission is a personal, individual command to every child of God to go into his/her own world and make an honest attempt to convert every person who will listen.

The New Testament does not place the responsibility for winning the world on a corporate, ethereal, group of people. The responsibility for evangelism is upon every individual Christian.

The first and greatest passion of Jesus was **“to seek and save the lost”** Luke 19:10. To follow the example of Jesus, we cannot be satisfied with the status quo; we must believe that something effective can be done to win souls. Individual Christians must become everything God wants us to be. We must find a way to recapture the passion of those early Christians in the book of Acts.

Souls are the very heartbeat of God and His people must return by His people to the philosophical stance that it is no longer acceptable to have empty pews, empty discipleship classes and least of all empty altars. After all, **the business of the Church is changed lives:**

- An auto repair shop cannot survive without repairing automobiles
- A carpenter cannot survive without something to build
- A bank cannot make it without lending money
- A hospital cannot stay in business without patients

The church is pretty much worthless and will in fact cease without evangelism and new converts.

In this series of messages I am not only going to challenge you to share your faith, I am also going to give you practical ways to go about it.

The message of the parables of Luke 15 is often overlooked:

- **The parable of the lost sheep (Vs. 3-7)**

- The parable of the woman with two coins (Vs. 8-9)
- The parable of the prodigal son (Vs. 11-32)

Most casual readers of the Word of God see no connection between these parables at all. Upon closer study, all of them are intricately connected. The message of Jesus is that every person is important to God. Bill Hybels makes the following statement in his book, Becoming a Contagious Christian, *“You’ve never looked eyes with another human being who isn’t valuable to God.”* Think of it. Everyone is valuable to God:

- The parking lot attendant
- The clerk at the grocery store
- The clerk at the convenience store
- The waiter or waitress serving the table
- The panhandler on the street corner (We tend to look away)

Every person is so valuable to God that He gave His Son and is not prepared for anyone to be lost! John 3:16-17 (NKJV) *“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.*
¹⁷*“For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but that the world through Him might be saved.”*

There are many prejudices that keep people from hearing the gospel of Christ:

- Prejudice of the lost - The lost convince themselves Christians do not want to associate

with them or care about their needs, problems, or concerns in life.

- **Prejudice of Christians toward the lost** - Christians who are afraid they will be contaminated by the lost.
- **Prejudice of religion** - This is undercover Christians who hide away in their homes, churches, and fellowship groups; developing only Christian relationships.

The church must dispense with the hold-the-fort mentality and develop an aggressive plan to break through all prejudices and barriers to present the Gospel to everyone.

END OF SERMON TWO...

(USE ATTENDANCE BOARD TO HIGHLIGHT THE FOLLOWING)

- Saved Last week - 13
- Invited last week - 64
- Saved this week - 87
- Invited this week - 3

(SHARE RESULTS OF SURVEY CARDS)

- 464 Responses
- Years Saved, 10,255
- Total Number led to Christ, 1,462
- Total number invited to church last year, 1,985

Based on these stats it takes this congregation seven years to lead a person to Christ. Each person who

responded to the survey invited 4.3 people to Church in the last 12 months. That is one per quarter, per person! I ask you this question: Can we grow this church by inviting one person per quarter?

I suspect these figures are overly complementary of us based on the fact that about half of this congregation did not turn in a survey card, probably because the questions are too painful. Plus two people said they had led 100 people to Christ and two or three people said they had invited in excess of 100 people to Church in 2007.

I am convinced we will do better in 2008.

The formula we are going to work with over the next few weeks is going to be: $HP + CP + CC = MI$

Simply put, this is $\text{High Potency} + \text{Close Proximity} + \text{Clear Communication} = \text{Maximum Impact}$.

I. HIGH POTENCY...

Acts 1:8 states that when the Holy Spirit comes upon the Christian, “You shall become witnesses”

- **In Jerusalem** - (At home and among family)
- **Judea** - (In my neighborhood)
- **Samaria** - (At work and in business)
- **To the uttermost parts of the earth** - (In all relationships and everywhere we go)

Whether we have been good stewards or bad stewards of our faith; whether we have been bold or intimidated in sharing our faith; whether we have souls to lay at

His feet or we stand there empty-handed; the fact is that not only have we been instructed to share our faith, we have been furnished the power to do so. Acts 1:8 (KJV) ***“But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.”***

The words of Acts 1:8 mark the beginning of the Christian Church. Not only do they mark the birthday of the church, they reveal:

- The heart of the church
- The calling of the church
- The purpose of the church
- The potential of the church

The question remains: Just what kind of power does the Holy Spirit furnish to the believer to become a contagious Christian?

THE ATTRACTIVENESS OF AUTHENTICITY

The Holy Spirit in the life of the believer furnishes the power to live life in an authentic fashion. Far too many professing Christians have a profession without a possession. When the Holy Spirit takes up residence within us, he makes us audio-visual Christians 24/7!

The lost can spot a phony a mile away. We must remember that those who do not know Christ come equipped with hypocrisy radars. (My experience with a radar detector)

If we are “*Playing church*” they can spot it before we have a chance to attempt to make a difference in their lives. If they spot areas in our lives where our actions do not live up to our words, we are through before we begin!

Joe Aldrich, who wrote a book, entitled “*Lifestyle Evangelism*” says, “*Christians are to be good news before they share the good news.*”

People will follow individuals who:

- Are real
- Are sincere
- Own up to their mistakes

The story is told of a General who had just set up his make-shift tent in Iraq and he turned to see a young private coming toward his tent. Wanting to appear important, he picked up his telephone and said, “*Yes, yes, Mr. President, I think that is an excellent plan, you’ve got my support on it. Thanks for checking with me today and keep in touch.*” When he hung up the telephone he looked at the private and said, “*Can I help you?*” The private said, “*I am here to hook up your telephone.*”

People who are considering a change in their lives do not expect perfection but they do expect:

- Sincerity
- Humility
- Repentance
- Forgiveness
- Restitution

In short, what they want to see is authenticity.

The fact is that none of us possesses the ability to live right. The Holy Spirit furnishes the power for authentic Christian living. When we live out our profession, we develop an audience of potential converts over whom we have influence. We should use that influence to lead them to Christ.

THE PULL OF COMPASSION

John 13:34-35 (NKJV) ***"A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another; as I have loved you, that you also love one another.*** ³⁵***"By this all will know that you are My disciples, if you have love for one another.***"

The philosophy of this world is:

- Make an attempt to succeed no matter who you hurt in the process
- Honesty is the best policy unless it goes against what you are attempting to do
- Put others first as long as it does not place your dream in jeopardy
- Get all you can and can all you get

The philosophy of this world does not lend itself to compassion. This is why **compassion is such a powerful tool for reaching the lost.**

The Holy Spirit is given to the believer to cause the believer to:

- Think like Jesus

- Behave like Jesus
- Love like Jesus
- Show compassion like Jesus

The word compassion is used nineteen times in the Bible and in most of those verses we are being told that Jesus was “*Moved with compassion.*”

We live in a cold world devoid of compassion and one of the greatest witnesses available is when the believer allows the compassion of Christ to be revealed through them.

The law of sowing and reaping is in effect:

- Love generates love
- Mercy fosters mercy
- Kind words engender kind words
- Compassion produces compassion

Part of the reason the culture is so devoid of compassion is because of the pace of our schedules.

Lou Harris recently compared the American workplace with where it was fifteen years earlier. Here are the results:

- The average work week increased from 41 to 47 hours per week
- The average work week for management increased from 52 to 59 hours per week
- Actual leisure time shrunk by 37%

If you add to this, the pressure of two career households, single parent families, pressure for

children to excel academically, increase in the style of living, you quickly become aware that rather than a compassionate culture, we are creating a culture in crisis. Our culture in crisis is the result of an attempt to get through the weekly drill successfully. And God help-you if you should bump into such a person in the wrong way!

Christians may actually face a greater dilemma when it comes to time crunches because of the added pressure of a church schedule. Could it be that the enemy has filled the calendar at the church to take the opportunity for being salt and light away from the church? I am not advocating that the calendar should be cleared but I am saying it should be simplified to give believers an opportunity to interact with those who need this message most!

If we take the extra time we are afforded from simplifying the church calendar and just use it for I, me, my, and mine: We will actually be worse off rather than better off.

The Holy Spirit furnishes us the power to be compassionate in a culture focused on I, me, my, and mine. When we go out of our way to help an individual it gets their attention because it is such a departure from the norm. This is where we have a tremendous opportunity to share the love of Jesus.

Mother Teresa said, *“The wire is in you and me; the current is God. We have the power to let the current*

pass through us, use us, and produce the Light of the World – Jesus.”

THE STRENGTH OF SACRIFICE

Who can speak of sacrifice without talking about the ultimate sacrifice? Jesus gave it all up for us:

- Heaven
- Power and authority
- His autonomy
- Ultimately His life

We have all witnessed selfless sacrifices by others:

- A fireman going into a burning building to rescue a person he doesn't even know
- A policeman or paramedic pulling a total stranger from an accident about to explode
- A soldier giving his life for the freedom of people he will never meet

Never mind the big ticket items think about how far the little sacrifices go:

- He brought me flowers
- She made me dinner
- They called to check on us

The reason small sacrifices seem to carry such notoriety and importance in this culture is because of the self-absorbed manner in which we have become accustomed to living.

As contagious Christians we must be always on the lookout for opportunities to make sacrifices. Sacrifice is the stuff miracles are made of.

Some sacrifices contagious Christians can make which will be noticed by the un-churched:

- Sacrifice of time (Spend time with the lost)
- Sacrifice of resources (Quit telling the church what others have need of and take care of it yourself)
- Sacrifice of lifestyle (Living a Godly life in an Godless culture)

The Holy Spirit empowers the believer to:

- Attract the lost through an authentic lifestyle
- Connect with the lost through compassion
- Show the lost how much we care through sacrifice

(HAVE CHRIS CARROLL TO HAVE THE PERSON PRESENT WHO WON HIM TO THE LORD)

END OF SERMON 3

(USE ATTENDANCE BOARD TO HIGHLIGHT THE FOLLOWING)

- Saved Last week - 3
- Invited last week - 87
- Saved this week - 10
- Invited this week - 152

The formula we are working with in this series is,
High Potency + Close Proximity + Clear
Communication = Maximum Impact.

II. CLOSE PROXEMITY

Make no mistake about it. Relationships are central to everything we do and they are a precondition to soul winning. When a relationship is not required to convert a person, you can rest assured that someone else has laid the groundwork.

Developing relationships of any kind requires massive amounts of time and effort, not to mention the anxiety involved with attempting to forge a relationship with persons whose value system is different from ours.

We all have a propensity to gravitate toward developing relationships with people who have similar:

- Interests
- Values
- Family structures
- Spiritual values

Once friendships are forged:

- Friends tend to hang out together at the exclusion of others
- Friends are prone to take advice from one another despite the lack of experience
- Friends tend to influence each other in almost every sector of life
- Friends tend to make purchases from people they have a relationship with or people their

friends have a relationship with (In business it is called “*Word of mouth advertising.*”)

The mistake most Christians make is to jump the gun on offering spiritual advice before the friendship has been solidified. When we develop relationships with people for the purpose of leading them to Christ, we must be patient enough to wait for the proper time to make our move. [James 1:4](#) (NKJV) “Let *patience* have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing.” [Hebrews 10:36](#) (NKJV) “Ye have need of patience, that, *after ye have done the will of God, ye might receive the promise.*”

The institute of American Church Growth polled 4,000 people as to how they were influenced to first attend the services of the church where they eventually became converts:

- 2% -3% just walked in
- 2%-3% came through the churches program
- 5%-6% were attracted by the preacher
- 1%-2% came out of a special need
- 1%-2% was reached through visitation programs
- 4%-5% came through a Sunday School class
- ½%-1% came through a public evangelistic crusade
- 75%-90% were converted through the influence of friends and relatives

What that should tell us is that the souls of millions depend on us! Here is a staggering statement, “*When Jesus comes again, they will or won’t be prepared, largely because of how we did our job as Christians.*”

I want us to personalize this statement. Place a name and face of someone you love on that statement;

“When Jesus comes again, _____ will, or won’t be prepared, based on how I did my job as a Christian.”

The fact that we claim to believe the coming of the Lord is imminent should stir us to action! The eternal destiny of our family and friends rest squarely on the shoulders of those of us who are sitting in this room today.

(EXERCISE)

- Have the ushers to distribute a blank piece of paper to each person
- Once everyone has a piece of paper, ask them to write down the name of three un-churched people with whom they have a relationship which could be used to lead that person to Christ
- Stop all writing within sixty seconds
- Have everyone to stand who has written the name of three people
- Have the ushers to count how many people were able to do this
- Have everyone to complete their list using the names of people they feel they could develop this kind of relationship with
- Ask the congregation to keep this list with them throughout the remainder of this series and listen to the information which will be shared while thinking of the people on their impact list

- Ask the congregation to make notes of ideas they could use with regard to the people on their impact list

I realize this sermon flies in the face of what some of us have been taught for years, which is to separate ourselves from this world. [James 4:4](#) (NKJV)

“Adulterers and adulteresses! Do you not know that friendship with the world is enmity with God?

Whoever therefore wants to be a friend of the world makes himself an enemy of God.” In his second letter to the Corinthians, Paul quotes God on this subject. [2 Corinthians 6:14](#) (NKJV) ***“Come out from among them And be separate, says the Lord. Do not touch what is unclean, And I will receive you.”***

Some of you are probably asking yourself the question, *“If the Scripture says such things, why in the world would our Pastor be encouraging us to make worldly friends?”* The answer is simple: I believe the Scripture is speaking of lifestyles rather than relationships. I believe it is possible to associate with the world without participating in their sin! Recently, Susan was invited to join a Bunco Group in our subdivision. Susan loves to play Bunco. She decided not to do so because the invitation she was sent for the organizational meeting stated they would be having cocktails! She felt and I believed she did the right thing! In light of what the Scripture say’s about being the light of the world the best decision might have been to attend and join! How could I say that as a Pastor? Susan has never consumed a drop of alcohol and would not be tempted to do so. She had nothing to

lose and everything to gain. The neighbor ladies were actually inviting her to begin establishing a relationship with them! We did the Christian thing and said NO!!!

Allow me to pose a question: If Christians are supposed to be constantly huddling in spiritual circles of influence, how is our light going to shine in a dark world? [Isaiah 60:1-3](#) (NKJV)

“Arise, shine; For your light has come! And the glory of the LORD is risen upon you. ² For behold, the darkness shall cover the earth, And deep darkness the people; But the LORD will arise over you, And His glory will be seen upon you. ³ The Gentiles shall come to your light, And kings to the brightness of your rising.”

Jesus spent the majority of his time with what we would call the un-churched:

- [Sinners](#) - People who were publicly known to be morally and ceremonially unclean!
- [Tax collectors](#) - Men who, as a result of their position, had a license to steal from the down trodden!
- [Prostitutes](#) - Women who were engaging in illicit sexual activity for the purpose of generating a livelihood!

Jesus was chided for such activity. In fact, Matthew threw a party for Jesus and invited some pretty shady and questionable guests. [Luke 5:27-30](#) (NKJV) ***“After these things He went out and saw a tax collector named Levi (Matthew), sitting at the tax office. And He said to him, “**Follow Me.**” ²⁸So he left all, rose up,***

and followed Him. ²⁹Then Levi gave Him a great feast in his own house. And there were a great number of tax collectors and others who sat down with them.” Matthew was a new follower of Jesus and he probably was not aware that he would raise the religious and political temperature to such a level, but there was some major fallout from Matthew’s party.

[Luke 5:30](#) (NKJV) *“And their scribes and the Pharisees complained against His disciples, saying, “Why do You eat and drink with tax collectors and sinners?”* Listen to the manner in which Jesus responds to such accusations. [Luke 5:31-32](#) (NKJV) *“Jesus answered and said to them, “Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick.”³² “I have not come to call the righteous, but sinners, to repentance.”*

Matthew had become a follower of Jesus and threw a party with a purpose!

(HAVE SUSAN TALK ABOUT IDEAS FOR PARTIES WITH A PURPOSE)

Paul seemed to embrace the strategy of Jesus and the strategy I am promoting when he said, [1 Corinthians 9:22-23](#) (NKJV) *“I have become all things to all men, that I might by all means save some.”*

While encouraging you to develop relationships with the un-churched, I also want to sound an alarm; [if your relationships are enticing you to participate in compromising behavior, you need to flee from, rather than maintain the relationship.](#) [Galatians 6:1](#) (NKJV)

“Brethren, if a man is overtaken in any trespass, you who are spiritual restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness, considering yourself lest you also be tempted.” Nothing is worth losing your soul over.
Matthew 16:24 (NKJV) “For what profit is it to a man if he gains the whole world, and loses his own soul? Or what will a man give in exchange for his soul?”

The church **MUST** begin to do what Jesus, Paul, Matthew, Zaccheaus and others did - develop intentional relationships for the purpose of leading people to Christ. **Proverbs 11:30 (NKJV) “The fruit of the righteous is a tree of life, And he who wins souls is wise.”**

Winning souls **MUST** become non-negotiable and we **MUST** not lose sight of the task being:

- Person to person
- Friend to friend
- Neighbor to neighbor
- Co-worker to co-worker

The business of soul winning is:

- Logical
- Strategic
- Purposeful
- Biblical

We have been commanded to be contagious Christians who develop relationships and strategies to win the lost.

END OF SERMON 4

(USE ATTENDANCE BOARD TO HIGHLIGHT THE FOLLOWING)

- Saved Last week - 10
- Invited last week - 152
- Saved this week - 5
- Invited this week - 135

The formula we are working with for this series is,
High Potency + Close Proximity + Clear Communication = Maximum Impact.

III. CLEAR COMMUNICATION

We have talked extensively about the need for relationships and the importance of modeling Christianity within those relationships. While it is true that nothing can take the place of such interaction with the un-churched, this in-and-of-itself may never be enough.

One of the significant things to bear in mind as we develop such associations is that we must always be on the lookout for opportunities which God will no doubt provide, to turn the conversation to things which are intentionally designed to share our faith in comprehensible ways.

Relationships are good, even necessary, but eventually the gospel must be presented through words. **Romans 10:13-17** (NKJV) ***“Whoever calls on the name of the LORD shall be saved.” ¹⁴How then shall they call on Him in whom they have not believed? And how shall***

*they believe in Him of whom they have not heard? And how shall they hear without a preacher?¹⁵ And how shall they preach unless they are sent? As it is written: “How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the gospel of peace, Who bring glad tidings of good things!”¹⁶ But they have not all obeyed the gospel. For Isaiah says, “Lord, who has believed our report?”¹⁷ So then faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.” As Paul writes to the Roman Christians he outlines some **problems as they relate to reaching the un-churched** which were pervasive in the Roman Church and are equally accurate in our culture:*

- **People cannot come to faith without first believing in Christ** - (A charismatic church recently placed a bill-board which read, “*You do not have to believe to belong.*”) You MUST believe to belong!
- **How are they going to believe in a Christ whom they have never heard of?**
- **How will they believe in Christ unless a messenger presents the message?**
- **How will Christians present the message unless they are equipped and motivated to do so?**
- **Faith in Christ comes through an exchange of hearing and words** - The un-churched do the hearing and the believer reduces the Gospel to words!

END OF SERMON 5

(USE ATTENDANCE BOARD TO HIGHLIGHT THE FOLLOWING)

- Saved Last week - 5
- Invited last week - 135
- Saved this week - 12
- Invited this week - 115

The formula we are working with in this series is,
**High Potency + Close Proximity + Clear
 Communication = Maximum Impact.**

It is clear that the initiative of guiding the conversation toward opportunities for the presentation of the Gospel rests squarely on the shoulders of the believer. How and when to give rise to topics of faith, are always at the discretion of the believer who is being led by the Holy Spirit. There are basically three methods of steering conversations toward spiritual things:

DIRECT METHOD

This method does not await opportune moments in conversations, but intentionally creates such an opening. This kind of an opening can be created with statements such as;

- *“If you would ever like to know the difference between religion and relationship, I would love to discuss it with you.”*
- *“How would you define a real Christian?”*
- *“I am curious, do you ever think about spiritual matters?”*
- *“Who, in your opinion, was Jesus Christ?”*
- *“What is your spiritual background?”*
- *“Where are you headed in your spiritual journey?”*

- *“Do you ever wonder what happens to us when we die?”*

This direct approach is precisely what Jesus did with the woman at the well in John chapter Four. [John 4:7-10](#) (NKJV) *“A woman of Samaria came to draw water. Jesus said to her, **“Give Me a drink.”** ⁸For His disciples had gone away into the city to buy food. ⁹Then the woman of Samaria said to Him, “How is it that You, being a Jew, ask a drink from me, a Samaritan woman?” For Jews have no dealings with Samaritans. ¹⁰Jesus answered and said to her, **“If you knew the gift of God, and who it is who says to you, ‘Give Me a drink,’ you would have asked Him, and He would have given you living water.”*** Quite frankly, you cannot get much more direct than that. The direct method should be used:

- With caution
- At the appropriate times
- With people whose personalities can handle it

INDIRECT METHOD

With a little forethought and practice, almost anyone can master this method. For instance in:

- **Business** – When someone asks, *“What kind of year are you having?”* One could say, *“Financially, okay; with the family, very well; spiritually, I am terrific; which one would you like to talk about?”*
- **Holidays** – When discussing the holidays a believer can say: At Easter – *“What do you believe about the resurrection?”* On Memorial Day – *“What do you think happens to a person*

after they die?” On Independence Day – “I appreciate the freedom I have as an American but it is nothing compared to the freedom I have found as a Christian.” On Labor Day – “The things we accomplish through our employment pale in significance to the things we do for Christ.” On Thanksgiving – “The thing I am most thankful for is a personal relationship with Christ.” At Christmas – “Do you believe the baby in the manger was the Son of God?”

- **Hobbies and spare time** – When asked what you do with your spare time one could say, *“On the weekends I enjoy golf and attending my church.”* This may open the door to offer an invitation from the believer to the unbeliever to attend church together.
- **Nature** - When engaged in a conversation about nature the believer can say, *“God must have had a terrific imagination when He created the world.”*
- **Music** – When being asked what kind of music the believer enjoys, the opportunity is present to mention Christian artists or Christian music.
- **Sports** – With so many sports figures becoming Christians, this is an easy transition. For instance, if I were talking to someone about football right now I would probably mention that I recently read Tony Dungy's book *“Quiet Strength.”* I would probably add, *“Did you know Coach Dungy is a Christian?”*
- **Struggles of life** – This is also a pretty easy transition. When people begin to speak with us about what they are struggling with, whether it

is related to health, marriage, or children we can say, *“Let me tell you who helped me navigate the most difficult time in my life.”*

INVITATIONAL METHOD

Inviting people to church-related events has two wonderful benefits:

- They might actually attend
- If they decline, this is an opportunity to say something like: *“I understand you are very busy, maybe next time. By the way, were you raised in a religious family?”*

No matter what approach we decide to take we should keep in mind the following principles:

- **Pray consistently** - No man comes to God except the Spirit draws him.
- **Talk to people privately and individually** - Using positive peer pressure or ambushing people among our Christian buddies is never a very good choice.
- **Maximize their curiosity** - Consistently leave hints that something is different in our lives.
- **Seize split-second opportunities** - Be constantly of the lookout for opportunities to drop hints about Christ. Never underestimate the unbeliever's degree of interest. They may not appear interested at the moment, but they are archiving the information which will be recalled at a later date. **Isaiah 55:11 (NKJV) “So shall My word be that goes forth from My mouth; It shall not return to Me void, But It shall accomplish what I please,**

And it shall prosper in the thing for which I sent it."

No matter how or to whom we are attempting to communicate the Gospel message, **we must make sure we clearly describe God as:**

- Holy
- Good
- Loving
- Approachable
- Compassionate

One of the great hurdles Christians must navigate in sharing their faith is that the un-churched believe religion and Christianity to be one and the same. **We must clearly communicate the differences between religion and Christianity:**

- Religion: This can be described in two letters, DO – It is all about rules!
- Christianity: This can be described in four letters DONE – Jesus did it all for us!

In order to be an effective witness, a believer must **keep the following things in mind:**

- **Don't give a speech** - People want to talk to us, not to be talked to by us!
- **Give the Gospel in doses** - Rome was not built in a day and the chances are that our friends will not come to Christ on our first attempt to convert them!

- **Be bold** - Remember, this is the most important topic we will ever discuss with our friends and relatives!

Remember: People are interested in hearing our story, so why not become a contagious Christian and tell it often?

SHOW VIDEO OF KEN & KELLY WILSON

END OF SERMON 6

(USE ATTENDANCE BOARD TO HIGHLIGHT THE FOLLOWING)

- Saved Last week – 12
- Invited last week - 115
- Saved this week - 2
- Invited this week - 120

The formula we are working with for this series is,
High Potency + Close Proximity + Clear Communication = Maximum Impact.

IV. MAXIMUM IMPACT

Jesus' model for building the church, saving the lost, populating heaven, and de-populating hell were to use the lives and lips of dedicated disciples to turn their world upside down. It is interesting that Jesus seemed to believe that if He could get twelve guys to buy into His philosophy and they in turn would do the same thing that the world would be won in short order.

Look at the results in the First Century Church:

- 3,000 saved the first day (Acts 2:37-38)

- God added to the church daily such as should be saved (Acts 2:47)
- 2,000 are saved at Solomon's Porch (Acts 3:1-4)
- The Samaritans become Christians (Acts 8:1-12)
- Men and women were baptized following their conversion (Acts 8:12-13)
- The Ethiopian eunuch is converted (Acts 8:36-39)
- Saul (Paul) receives Christ (Acts 9:18)
- The household of Cornelius gets saved (Acts 10:43)
- The people of Antioch are converted (Acts 11:19-21)
- Sergius Paulus becomes a Christian on the island of Paphos (Acts 13:4-12)
- Many Jews and religious proselytes follow Paul and Barnabas at Antioch in Pisidia (Acts 13:13-48)
- A great multitude follows Christ at Iconium (Acts 14:1)
- An undetermined number of people make decisions for Christ at Lystra and Derbe (Acts 14)
- The Philippian jailer and his family become followers of Christ (Acts 16)
- Lydia comes to faith in Christ (Acts 16)
- A great multitude of the Greeks and many of the leading women join themselves to the faith at Thessalonica (Acts 17:1-12)
- The conversion of the Athenians at Mars Hill (Acts 17:16-34)

- Many Corinthian people are converted (Acts 18:8)
- At Corinth, Aquila and his wife Pricilla follow Jesus (Acts 18:24-28)
- The twelve disciples of John the Baptist are converted (Acts 19:1-10)

Think of this, if twelve people in this church would commit to winning one person a year, and making that convert into a disciple who brings a person a year to Christ over a twenty year period, 12,582,900 would be won to the Lord!

The place where this plan went wrong is when the discipleship process turned inward rather than outward; toward fattening up the saints rather than creating disciple making disciples.

Christian Temple is a great church but I am determined to move our discipleship process to the ultimate level of creating disciple-making disciples of every person who is willing to become one.

If the process of discipleship stalls before a disciple is transformed into a disciple-making disciple then we have settled for becoming a sheep-fattening plant rather than a soul-saving station!

If we are to achieve the desired goal of becoming a high-impact Christian and a high-impact church we must dispense with the expectation of the un-churched coming to church on their own and adopt a philosophy which takes the church to them in an effort of bringing

them to church and ultimately to Christ! We must learn the art of reaching people:

- How they are
- Where they are

The church must develop a lizard mentality and put to death the frog mentality which has crippled us.

FROG MENTALITY

Frogs sit and wait until their food walks, flies, or swims past. Then they pounce. In the world of the frog, everything comes to those who wait. Tragically, the frog mentality has been the philosophical stance of the church over the past several decades. The result is that church attendance is in decline and even worse, conversions are not even keeping pace with births, thus, attrition is gaining ground on the church! Reality is that if attrition is gaining ground on the church conversion rate, souls are perishing at an unprecedented rate!

LIZARD MENTALITY

Lizards go out in search of food. In the lizard world everyone would be dead if they waited for the activity to come to them. With 160 million un-churched people in America and 153 million willing to go to church if they were to be invited, we must go where they are and bring them with us to church and into the Kingdom of God. Goodbye Frog Evangelism, hello Lizard Discipleship.

The indoors-insider-ingrown mentality of the church must cease and Christians must be pushed out-of-doors and into a culture which has lost its way!

It's time the church lost some of its religion to gain its life. The life of the church is the converting of the un-churched!

I believe we must give up thinking in terms of the masses; because we have 1,500-1,600 people show up for a worship service or discipleship class each week does not necessarily mean we are doing a good job!

Retraining the church to think small enough to reconsider the value of an individual will bring about big-hearted Christians!

The postmodern culture has made a break with the thinking of the generation before them and they believe that smaller is better. As a result we hear words like:

- Nano
- Micro
- Meta
- Mini

The mathematics of Jesus seems to give credence to such a mindset! In the story of a flock of one hundred sheep, Jesus is concerned because one is lost! For all practical purposes, it would appear that the one lost sheep is worth as much or more than the ninety-nine sheep that were safe! The real story here is that getting one person saved is worth the inconvenience

and risk of everyone else! Why is this so? The fate of the ninety-nine hinges on what happens to the one.

What happens to the whole depends on how the smallest parts are treated!

The mass mentality must cease in the church! The tiniest responsibilities of the church must be reconsidered. Reaching the lost must become non-negotiable. Vance Havner once said, *"We may be many, but we ain't much!"*

The biblical story of the disciples ripping apart the roof of a house to get their friend to Jesus who was desperate to be healed is a good example of what this post-modern culture needs the church to become:

- The most pressing need was a miracle
- No thought was given to how this might affect the home owner
- Not one negative word is recorded of the home owner's reaction to their destructive but redemptive actions
- The only consideration is the need of the man who was desperate for a miracle

The church should take a lesson from this story:

- Buildings are not a goal, they are a tool
- The treasury is less important than the need of the people
- Less consideration should be given to what we can afford to do, and more thought should be given to what we must do

- The only consideration should be to do what we have been commanded to do, which is to TAKE this Gospel all over the world

What does this type of ministry look like in the local church?

- Each church must tailor their ministry to reflect their core values - Reaching the lost must be at the top of the list.
- The budget of the church will reveal what its priorities are - We throw money at what is important to us!
- Each believer is constantly cognizant of the repercussions of their words and deeds - (Audio visual Christians 24/7)
- Each believer is challenged to develop a relationship with the people in their neighborhood by using various kinds of ideas
- Each believer develops relationships with the un-churched and is constantly looking for opportunities afforded by such relationships to bring their friends to Christ - (i.e. Holiday Parties, Events for Kids on the Block, Pie Parties)

In light of the fact that we believe the return of Jesus to be imminent, the church MUST do everything possible to have maximum impact!

Invited – 726

Saved – 54

7.38% of the people invited have accepted Christ!

High Potency + Close Proximity + Clear
Communication = Maximum Impact.